sentry box just outside the main gate, which we did up and got the SBI to install an ATM there. Not as easy as it sounds, as for the ATM to function, it has to be connected to the network. So first, we had to find a solution to have foolproof network connectivity, which was achieved by engineering a circuit through the Wireless in Local Loop (WLL), as BSNL did not have the wherewithal, nor were they inclined to extend a line to the middle of nowhere.

All the Brigade locations, Phulbari, Thakurbari, Amrabari, were in the middle of the tea gardens. The Phulbari Tea Estate actually surrounded our garrison on all sides. This estate was part of the range of tea estates owned by the McLeod Russel India Ltd (MRIL) group of tea producers. McLeod Russel began planting tea in India in 1869 and today is the largest tea-producing company in the world. They were our neighbours, so to speak, and we soon made friends with the planters. Most of the tea gardens had been established by former Army officers and they had replicated the ethos and work culture of the armed forces, so it was but natural that we got along. Mr Ravinder Singh Manhas of the Phulbari estate, my closest neighbour, was the son of an Army officer of the Sikh Regiment. His wife, Raman, was senior coordinator at the Assam Valley Public School, one of the most prestigious schools in Assam. Ravinder invited us to the estate and explained the whole process that goes into making your morning cup of tea. Right from the plucking to the sorting and airing of the leaves, the intricacies of temperature and humidity, what is meant by the term 'first flush' and a tour of the factory itself, where the aroma of tea permeated the air. We saw the cut, tear, curl (CTC) method of processing black tea, in which the leaves are processed into small, hard pellets, unlike the orthodox tea, in which the leaves are rolled

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